Backlinks vs. Referring Domains: How to Read the Numbers Without Getting Misled

A backlink report can look impressive and still leave a business owner with a basic question: are these links helping the right pages reach the right customers? The answer is not in the largest number on the dashboard.

First, know what you are counting

A backlink is a link from one web page to another. A referring domain is a unique website domain that links to your page or site at least once. These are related metrics, but they answer different questions.

Imagine that one website links to your online store from 40 separate pages. A backlink tool may report 40 backlinks, but only one referring domain. If five independent websites each link to the store once, that is five backlinks from five referring domains.

Neither scenario is automatically better. The difference simply tells you whether the links are concentrated on a few sites or distributed across different ones.

Why the biggest backlink count can mislead

A high backlink count can include repeated links from the same website, template-wide navigation, links from unrelated pages, and links that no longer point where you expect. It can also include legitimate editorial references that are genuinely useful. Counting alone does not separate those cases.

The opposite mistake is treating referring domains as a magic score. Ten domains publishing relevant, helpful references are not necessarily less valuable than 100 unrelated domains, but the number itself cannot establish the value of either group. Third-party authority scores can support prioritization; they are not Google ranking scores.

Google also discourages creating or buying links mainly to manipulate search rankings. If a placement is sponsored, it should be identified appropriately rather than presented as a natural editorial endorsement.

An e-commerce example: a real business question, not a made-up SEO result

Consider a smaller electronics retailer such as Refahston, which sells digital products and offers installment-purchase options. A shopper considering a laptop may want to know more than its processor and price. They may also need clear information about deposit requirements, payment terms, eligibility, delivery, and warranty.

Now imagine two potential links to that retailer. One comes from a relevant consumer guide that helps readers compare payment options and directs them to a useful, transparent explanation. Another appears in the footer of an unrelated directory that links to hundreds of shops. The first has a clearer reason to exist for the reader. That makes it a more sensible opportunity to investigate, even before looking at authority metrics.

This is an illustrative comparison, not a claim that either link exists or improved Refahston’s rankings. A proper audit would verify the linking page, destination, context, link attributes, and actual performance data.

A practical five-step backlink review

1. Define the page and the business goal. Are you assessing a product page, a category, or a buying guide? Decide whether success means qualified visits, inquiries, or completed purchases.

2. Export both reports. In a tool such as Ahrefs, review backlinks and referring domains separately. Record the date, chosen URL or domain scope, and filters so another analyst can reproduce the comparison.

3. Verify a useful sample. Open the source pages. Is the link live? Does it point to the intended page? Is the topic relevant? Is the anchor text natural? Is the link in the article, a profile, or a repeated template? Check whether sponsored, nofollow, or UGC attributes are present.

4. Evaluate the destination. A strong editorial mention cannot repair a page that fails to answer what the visitor came to learn. Review the page's main content, navigation, clarity, and next step before proposing a link campaign.

5. Measure the outcome carefully. Where access exists, monitor the target page's search impressions and clicks in Google Search Console, and the business outcomes through appropriately configured analytics. Look for patterns over time, but do not claim that a ranking change was caused by one link without stronger evidence.

What should a good backlink report actually say?

Instead of saying "We gained 120 backlinks," a useful report might say: "The current export shows links from a small group of relevant publishers, along with repeated links and placements that require verification. Our first priority is to confirm which references are live and whether the destination pages answer shoppers' questions."

That is less dramatic than a big total. It is also more useful. It tells a client what is known, what is uncertain, and what should happen next.

Frequently asked questions

Are referring domains more important than backlinks?

They answer different questions. Referring domains describe the diversity of websites linking to you; backlinks describe individual links. Evaluate both, then inspect relevance and context.

Does a higher Domain Rating guarantee higher Google rankings?

No. Domain Rating is a third-party metric, not a Google ranking score. Rankings depend on many factors, including whether a page is relevant and useful for a particular query.

Should an online shop pay for backlinks?

Do not buy links to manipulate rankings. Legitimate advertising and sponsorships should be clearly qualified with the appropriate link attributes under Google's guidance.

The takeaway

Read backlink data as evidence, not as a scoreboard. Start with the customer's search intent, check the linking source and destination, document uncertainty, and connect the work to a real business outcome. A better report explains what a business should do next—not just how many links a tool found.

References

Ahrefs Help Center — What's the Difference Between Referring Domains and Backlinks?

Google Search Central — Creating Helpful, Reliable, People-First Content.

Google Search Central — Spam Policies for Google Web Search.

Google Search Central — Qualify Outbound Links.